

EMAIL SUBJECT -----

The PMM role isn't shrinking, it's changing, and we must embrace this honestly.

EMAIL BODY-----

Team,

I want to talk directly about something most of us are already feeling, but probably not hearing acknowledged or said out loud enough.

Following the recent reorganization, Product Marketing at IBM has shifted from a model where we held clearer authority over marketing direction, to one where many market-facing responsibilities are centralized. This means that our role is increasingly defined by power through influence rather than power through control.

If your first reaction is skepticism or frustration, that reaction is valid. Let me say what I won't pretend isn't true, some formal authority has moved out of our hands. Naming that isn't a weakness, it's the honesty I referenced in the subject line.

What I want to challenge is the idea that the loss of formal authority automatically means our impact is reduced. At the same time, it is important to acknowledge that it does mean the mechanics of our impact have changed.

In the prior model, authority allowed us to decide. In this new operating model, our effectiveness depends on whether we can shape thinking early enough, clearly enough, and credibly enough that decisions are already aligned before they reach a formal moment of approval.

That is harder work than writing an amazing piece of content. More importantly, it is different work, work that will help you to grow into future leaders. Doing this consistently and effectively requires a higher bar for PMM.

In this new environment, PMM is no longer valued for being the "owner of messaging" or the "final stop in the product launch process." We are valued for being the market conscience of the business. This new kind of PMM needs to detect market and competitive shifts before others do, articulate client truth in way that can affect direction AND message/language choices and creates clarity that other teams reuse as if it were their own.

That kind of impact doesn't come from org charts. It comes from earned authority through partnership and influence.

I know one likely objection already:

"If we're responsible in the eyes of the business unit, but only advisory in the eyes of centralized marketing, aren't we set up to fail?"

That risk exists, in fact, it's always existed. And pretending it doesn't exist would be irresponsible. That is why this shift only works if we change how we operate as a PMM organization (and as a PMM) as well.

Here is my commitment to you:

- I will be explicit about where PMM input is non-negotiable, and I will escalate when it's bypassed.
- I will protect your time so influence work doesn't become "extra work."
- I will be clear about what excellence looks like in this model, and honest when the role or the person isn't aligned to it.

Here is what I'm asking in return:

- Lean into being architects, not approvers.
- Stop waiting for permission to shape the narrative upstream.
- Build influence through insight, clarity, and repetition, not proximity to process.

Some of you will thrive in this version of product marketing, and some of you may decide it's not the role you signed up for. Both reactions are legitimate and I will help you make the transition regardless of the path you choose.

What's not viable is clinging to an authority model that no longer exists and hoping it comes back. Our relevance going forward will not be determined by where we sit in the org, it will be determined by whether the business moves differently because we are in the room.

More to come, but for now, I wanted to be direct, not optimistic, and not evasive about this new reality.

Regards,

Scott